MBA: 8109 RESEARCH METHODS



Session 12 — Writing and Presenting the Project Report

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Structure | Write | Reference | Defend

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this session, the candidate should be able to

1. **Structure a project report** in line with the SU Thesis/Dissertation Presentation Guide (Appendix G).
2. **Apply an academic writing style:** formal register, appropriate voice, hedged claims, signposting, correct tenses and synthesis over quotation.
3. **Prepare for an oral defence** or presentation of research findings.
4. **Check a draft chapter** against Strathmore's technical and referencing requirements before submission.

This week's activities

Appendix G walkthrough
Presentation standards, with examples

Academic writing clinic
Edit your own paragraph for register, hedging and synthesis

Referencing clinic
Regenerate, resolve and repair your reference list

Plus a deep dive into Chapter 5: summary, discussion, theoretical contribution, conclusions, recommendations, limitations and further research, and the mistakes to avoid.

Anatomy of a Strathmore dissertation

This week's focus: SBS combines Chapters 5 and 6 into one Chapter 5, as the SU Guide permits

Front matter	Ch 1 Introduction	Ch 2 Literature review	Ch 3 Methodology	Ch 4 Findings	Ch 5 Discussion	Ch 6 Conclusions & recs	Refs	Appen-dices

Roman: ii, iii, iv …

Arabic, consecutive: Chapter 1 begins on page 1 and numbering runs through the appendices

Front matter, in this order

- Title page (unnumbered)
- Declaration and approval (page ii)
- Abstract (from page iii; ≤ 500 words; no headings, citations or figures)
- Table of contents (headings word-for-word)
- Lists of figures, tables, abbreviations
- Acknowledgments; dedication (optional)

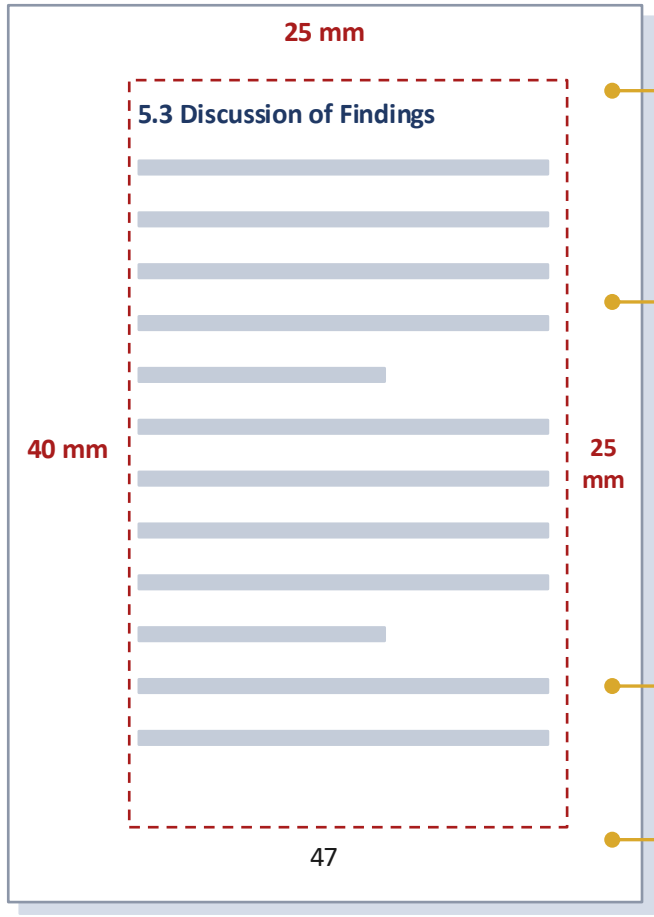
Body rules

- Each chapter starts on a new page; no display pages
- Headings to Level 3 (Level 4 if needed), numbered
- Master's thesis ≤ 50,000 words, excluding front matter, references and appendices
- Findings or literature may span two chapters, but keep the order

Back matter

- References: every work cited, and only works cited
- References come before the appendices
- Appendices A, B, C (or I, II, III); a single one is just 'Appendix'
- Appendix titles appear in the table of contents
- **Ethics evidence:** append the SU-IERC ethics approval letter and the NACOSTI research permit

Appendix G: the presentation standards examiners check



Illustrative A4 page to scale

- Left margin 40 mm for binding; 25 mm top, right and bottom
- Text 1.5-spaced; single spacing only for indented quotes and footnotes
- Page number centred at the bottom; no 'page', no dashes
- No running headers or footers

Typeface
11 or 12 pt Times New Roman, Arial, Book Antiqua or Helvetica; ≥ 10 pt inside tables

Headings
L1 14 pt bold · L2 12 pt bold · L3 12 pt bold italic · L4 12 pt italic

Tables and figures
Numbered by chapter (Table 4.1); captioned; placed after first mention; never grouped at the end

Cross-referencing
'As Table 4.1 shows…', never 'the table below'

Borrowed tables and figures
'Source:' at bottom right, including the page number

Citations
APA author–date(–page) in the text; never footnotes or endnotes for sources

Paper and pages
A4, one side; each chapter on a new page; no heading stranded at a page foot

Length
≤ 50,000 words in the body; abstract ≤ 500 words

A clear storyline runs from question to recommendation

1 What is my research question?
Chapter 1

2 What is my answer to it?
Chapter 5 conclusions

3 What evidence led me to that answer?
Chapters 3 and 4

Raimond's three-step storyline: if you can answer these in one minute, your abstract almost writes itself.

Test it by reasoning backwards, as a sceptical manager or examiner would



Every answer must already be in the report. If one link is missing, the storyline breaks, and this is exactly the chain an examiner follows in the oral defence. Each chapter should open with a preview and close with a short summary that hands over to the next.

Chapter 5: eight sections, one argument

Section		The question it answers	Indicative share of chapter
5.1	Introduction	*What does this chapter do, and in what order?*	3%
5.2	Summary of findings	*What did I find, objective by objective? (no tables)*	10%
5.3	Discussion of findings	*What do the findings mean against literature and theory?*	40%
5.4	Contribution of the study	*What do theory, practice and policy now know?*	10%
5.5	Conclusions	*What is the answer to each objective?*	10%
5.6	Recommendations	*Who should do what, based on which finding?*	15%
5.7	Limitations of the study	*How far can the findings be trusted and generalised?*	6%
5.8	Suggestions for further research	*What should the next study do differently or next?*	6%

SU Guide and SBS practice

The Guide lists Chapter 5 Discussion and Chapter 6 Conclusion and Recommendations and allows the two to be combined. At SBS they are combined into this one chapter.

Where you shine

Saunders et al. call the discussion the second big chance to show originality. It should be at least as long as your findings chapter, because it is where you make judgements rather than report facts.

Results report, discussion interprets, conclusions judge

Objective	Result (Ch 4) What I found	Discussion (5.3) What it means	Conclusion (5.5) My judgement	Recommendation (5.6) What to do
Cue words	*showed · was · rose*	*is consistent with · contrasts with · may be explained by*	*the study concludes · therefore*	*should · could consider*
What are the operational differences between shifts?	Indiscipline cases in the last six months were twice as frequent on the night shift as on the day shift.	The pattern may reflect operators' reluctance to work nights, a reading consistent with research linking night work to weaker supervision and commitment.	Night-shift indiscipline may be due to operators' reluctance to work this shift.	Pilot voluntary shift rotation and review night-supervision ratios.
Determine the effect of transformational leadership on employee engagement	Positive, significant effect: $\beta = 0.46$, $p < .001$; $R^2 = .21$ (Table 4.6).	Consistent with Author A (2021); contrasts with Author C (2020). Social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) explains the mechanism of reciprocation.	Transformational leadership significantly enhances engagement in Kenyan commercial banks; H_{01} is rejected.	Banks should build individual consideration into branch-manager development.

Same skeleton

Use the objective order from Chapter 1 in Chapters 4 and 5 so each finding has an obvious home.

No new material

Conclusions add no new data or literature; the discussion may add sources only if they explain your result.

Statistics stay in Ch 4

Cite a key figure once to anchor the point, then interpret; never re-paste tables.

Write the discussion in five moves, objective by objective

1. Restate

State the finding in one sentence, anchored by its key statistic.

"The results showed that…"

"Regarding the first objective…"

2. Compare

Set it against prior empirical studies: who agrees and who does not?

"This is consistent with…"

"In contrast to…"

3. Explain

Use the theory from Chapter 2 to explain why it happened.

"Social exchange theory suggests…"

"One explanation is…"

4. Contextualise

Account for differences: context, sector, culture, measures, design.

"This divergence may reflect…"

"In the Kenyan context…"

5. Imply

Say what it means for theory and practice: the 'so what'.

"These results suggest…"

"For managers, this implies…"

Organise by objective, not by statistical test or by questionnaire item.

Bring back every theory from Chapter 2: was it supported, extended or challenged?

Engage disagreement: contradictory studies are your best material, not a threat.

The five moves in one discussion paragraph

The first objective was to determine the effect of transformational leadership on employee engagement in Kenyan commercial banks. The results showed a positive and significant effect (β = 0.46, p < .001), with leadership explaining about 21% of the variance in engagement. This finding is consistent with Author A (2021) in Ghanaian banks and Author B (2022) in the Kenyan public service, but contrasts with Author C (2020), who reported no significant effect among South African call-centre staff. Social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) offers an explanation: when leaders provide individual consideration and inspiration, employees appear to reciprocate with greater cognitive and emotional investment in their roles (Kahn, 1990). The divergence from Author C may reflect the relational, high power-distance culture of Kenyan banks, in which leader behaviour carries particular weight, as well as that study's use of a single-item engagement measure. Taken together, these results suggest that social exchange theory extends to leadership–engagement relationships in East African service firms, and that leadership development may be a practical lever for engagement.

Author A, B and C are illustrative placeholders; Blau (1964) and Kahn (1990) are the theory sources.

Key

- 1. Restate
- 2. Compare
- 3. Explain
- 4. Contextualise
- 5. Imply

The weak version

"The study found that leadership affects engagement. This agrees with Author A (2021). Therefore, leadership is important."

One comparison, no theory, no context, an unhedged conclusion and no 'so what'.

Theoretical contribution: what does theory now know?

The contribution ladder



A sentence template for 5.4

Prior research [what was known] but [the gap from your Chapter 2 gap table]. This study found [key finding] in [context], which **extends / qualifies / challenges** [named theory] by showing [specific insight].

Pass Whetten's (1989) tests

What's new?	So what?	Why so?
Beyond the literature	Changes how we think	Logic and evidence

Theory	Practice	Policy
Named theories extended or qualified	Managers, boards and HR	Regulators such as CBK and ministries

Close the chapter: conclude, recommend, reflect, look ahead

5.5 Conclusions

One conclusion per objective, in order. Answer it, state the hypothesis decision, add no new data.

✗ *"Leadership is very important in banks."*

✓ *"Transformational leadership significantly enhances engagement in Kenyan commercial banks; H_{o1} is rejected and Objective 1 is achieved."*

5.6 Recommendations

Who + what + how, traced to a finding. Separate managerial, policy and theory recommendations.

✗ *"Banks should improve leadership."*

✓ *"HR directors of tier-two banks should embed coaching and individual consideration in branch-manager programmes, the dimension with the strongest effect (Objective 1)."*

5.7 Limitations

A mature reflection, not a confession: the limitation, its effect on the findings and how it was mitigated.

✗ *"Time and money were limited."*

✓ *"The cross-sectional, self-report design limits causal inference and risks common-method bias; procedural remedies and Harman's test were applied."*

5.8 Further research

Grow it from your limitations and from new questions your findings raise. Name the design, population or variable.

✗ *"More research should be done in this area."*

✓ *"A longitudinal, multi-source study extending to SACCOs and microfinance banks would test whether the effect holds over time and beyond tier-one banks."*

Ten Chapter 5 mistakes examiners see every year

Re-pasting Chapter 4 tables and statistics
→ Interpret; cite one key figure to anchor the point

Discussing findings without literature
→ Compare every finding with prior studies and theory

Citing only studies that agree
→ Engage contradictions and explain them

Theory in Chapter 2 vanishes in Chapter 5
→ Say whether each theory is supported, extended or challenged

No explicit theoretical contribution
→ Write 5.4, tied to the Chapter 2 gap

Causal claims from a cross-sectional survey
→ Use associational, hedged language

Conclusions that ignore the objectives
→ One conclusion per objective, in order

New data or literature in the conclusions
→ Conclude only on what is already presented

Generic recommendations ('should improve')
→ Name the actor and action; trace to a finding

'Time and money' limits; 'more research needed'
→ Methodological limits with effects; specific next studies

Academic style: tense, hedging and register

The tense map

Writing about…	Tense	Example
Established theory and general knowledge	Present	"Social exchange theory holds that…"
A specific prior study	Past (or present for the author's argument)	"Author A (2021) found…" · "Kahn (1990) argues…"
Your own method and findings	Past	"Data were collected from 210 managers." "The results showed…"
Interpretation and	Present, with	"This suggests…" ·

Person and voice

- Survey and positivist designs: third person or passive ("The study found…", "Data were collected…").
- Interpretivist designs may justify first person, because the researcher is part of the process (Saunders et al.).
- Avoid "the author"; choose one convention, agree it with your supervisor, and apply it consistently.

Match the strength of the claim to the evidence

◀ stronger — more tentative ▶

proves	demonstrates	shows	indicates	suggests	may / might

Rarely justified in survey research

Typical for significant survey results

Do not over-hedge: "it may possibly perhaps suggest" sounds evasive. One hedge per claim.

Register: replace the informal

I think / I feel	→ The evidence indicates
a lot of, huge	→ substantial, considerable
don't, can't	→ do not, cannot
X causes Y	→ X is associated with Y
etc. / and so on	→ a complete list

Writing clinic: from opinion to evidence-based argument

BEFORE

I think leadership is a very huge issue in banks today. According to Author A (2021), "leaders who inspire their followers achieve higher engagement" (p. 45). Author B (2022) said that "engagement is driven by leadership". My findings prove that leadership causes engagement, so banks must do a lot more training.

1. **Register**
   "I think", "very huge", "a lot" removed
2. **Synthesis**
   Two quotations → one paraphrase, grouped citation
3. **Hedging**
   "prove … causes" → "suggest … may"
4. **Signposting**
   "Consistent with", "However,", "because"
5. **Tense**
   Present perfect for the literature; past for own findings

AFTER

Transformational leadership has been consistently associated with higher employee engagement in service organisations (Author A, 2021; Author B, 2022). Consistent with this pattern, the present study found a positive and significant relationship in Kenyan commercial banks. However, because the design was cross-sectional, the results suggest, rather than establish, that leadership development may raise engagement.

Clinic task (10 minutes)

Pick 150 words
From your own Chapter 1–3 draft

Mark it up
Opinion, quotation, overclaim, tense

Rewrite
Apply the five fixes above

Swap and check
Partner applies the PEEL test

Referencing clinic: regenerate, resolve, repair, finalise

Clean the library
Complete metadata and DOIs in Zotero, Mendeley or EndNote

Cite only via plug-in
Never type a citation by hand
AI risk: chatbots invent fake sources

Regenerate the list
Refresh in APA 7th style

Cross-check
Every in-text citation resolves; every entry is cited

Finalise a copy
Update fields, then unlink on the submission copy

Four failure points to repair

Missing DOI

Kahn, W. A. (1990). Psychological conditions of personal engagement and disengagement at work. *Academy of Management Journal, 33*(4), 692–724. **[no DOI]**

Fix: Retrieve it in the library manager and add it as https://doi.org/…

Inconsistent initials

Bass, B. M. (1985) … Bass, B. (1985) …
In text: "(B. M. Bass, 1985; B. Bass, 1985)"

Fix: Merge duplicates; the software treats different initials as different authors

Title case in titles

Psychological Conditions Of Personal Engagement …

Fix: APA: sentence case for article and book titles; title case only for journal names

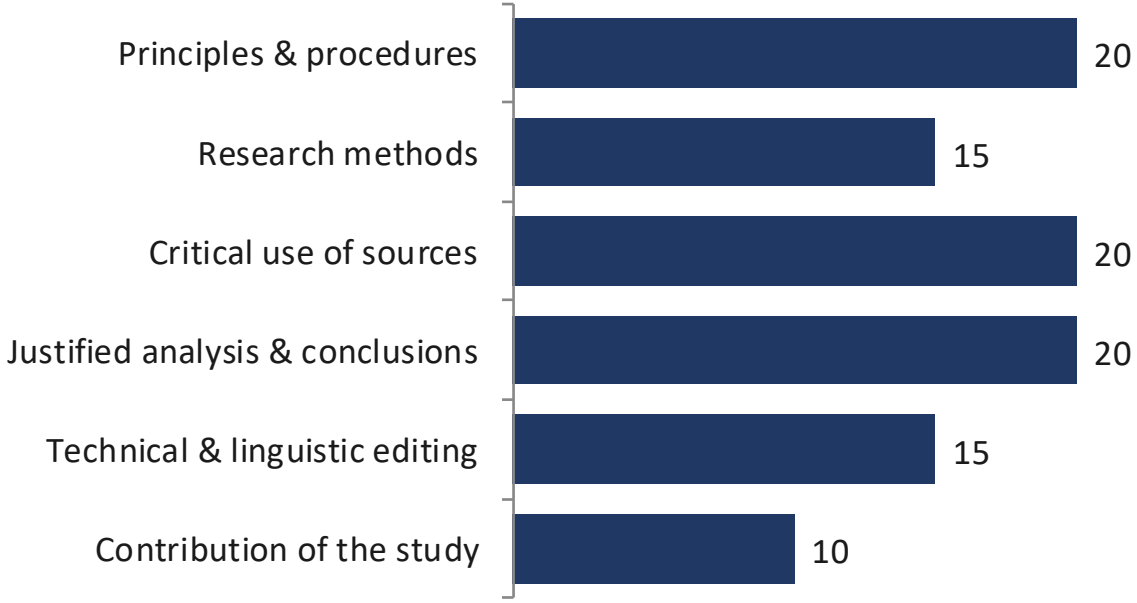
Grey field codes

(Blau, 1964)
Error! Reference source not found.

Fix: Update all fields (Ctrl+A, F9). Unlink citations only on the final copy; keep a live master

Check your draft the way the examiner will mark it

SU Guide Appendix H: marks out of 100



80% Written report

20% Oral defence

50% Pass mark in each

Self-audit before you submit a chapter

- [ ] Headings numbered, levels styled, matching the TOC
- [ ] Tables and figures numbered by chapter and cited by number
- [ ] Borrowed figures carry 'Source:' with page number
- [ ] 11–12 pt, 1.5 spacing, 40/25 mm margins, centred page numbers
- [ ] Every in-text citation resolves; every entry is cited
- [ ] APA 7th: DOIs, sentence case, consistent initials
- [ ] No grey field codes or 'Error!' messages remain
- [ ] Each objective answered; conclusions justified by the data
- [ ] Limitations acknowledged; contribution stated
- [ ] Spell-checked, proofread aloud and similarity report reviewed

Preparing for the oral defence

Shape of a 15-minute defence presentation

Problem & objectives	Literature & framework	Methodology	Findings	Discussion & contribution	Conclusions & recs
2 min	2min	3 min	5 min	2 min	2 min

Tell them three times

"First I tell them what I'm going to say, then I say it, then I tell them what I've said." (Parry, cited in Saunders et al.)

- One message per slide; key points, not script
- Rehearse to time, out loud
- Check the room and equipment beforehand

Questions to rehearse

- What is your contribution to knowledge?
- Why this design and sample, not another?
- How did you establish validity and reliability?
- Your result contradicts Author C. Why?
- How do your recommendations follow from your findings?
- What would you do differently?

Answering under pressure

- Pause; restate the question if unsure
- Answer, then point to the evidence ("Table 4.6 shows…")
- Concede a fair limitation; do not defend the indefensible
- Note corrections for the Appendix I correction form
- Keep answers short; let examiners probe